

10 Evidence-Backed Nootropic Stacks

A short, citation-first guide to ten stacks with the strongest human evidence — what works, what is hyped, and what to skip.

AUTHOR

Vera Huang, CMO — UCSD neuroscience

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READ TIME

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NEXT REVIEW

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AFFILIATE DISCLOSURE

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How we chose these stacks

We pulled from ~800 studies in our research library and applied three filters:

1. **At least one ingredient with Tier-1 or Tier-2 human evidence** (multiple RCTs, or a meta-analysis, or a well-replicated single trial in the target population).
2. **A coherent mechanism** for any supporting ingredients, even when their human evidence is thinner — and we say so out loud.
3. **A clean safety profile at the dose ranges we recommend.**

We report effect sizes the way the studies report them — actual deltas, the population studied, the duration. When evidence is mechanistic / animal / single-small-study, we flag it. **Structure and function language only.** Nootropics support cognitive function. They do not treat or cure conditions. If you suspect a clinical issue, talk to a clinician — that is not what this PDF is for.

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Focused Calm (Caffeine + L-Theanine)

Sharper attention without the jitter or crash.

Ingredients & doses (per serving):

- Caffeine: 80–100 mg (about one cup of coffee)
- L-Theanine: 200 mg
- Ratio: 1 : 2 caffeine to L-theanine is the most-studied combination

EVIDENCE SUMMARY

- Owen et al. (2008) — 50 mg caffeine + 100 mg L-theanine improved attention-switching accuracy and reduced susceptibility to distraction in 27 healthy adults vs. caffeine alone or placebo ([PubMed: 18681988](#)).
- Haskell et al. (2008) — 150 mg caffeine + 250 mg L-theanine improved simple reaction time and numeric working-memory speed and reduced "mental fatigue" ratings vs. each alone or placebo ([PubMed: 18006208](#)).
- Giesbrecht et al. (2010) — 40 mg caffeine + 97 mg L-theanine improved task-switching accuracy and self-reported alertness while reducing tiredness in 44 healthy young adults ([PubMed: 21040626](#)).

HONEST FRAMING

The effect on attention is real and replicated, but modest — measurable in the lab on reaction-time and accuracy tasks, not a personality change. The "without jitter" benefit comes from L-theanine attenuating the rise in blood pressure and subjective anxiety some people get from caffeine.

Who this is for: Knowledge workers who already drink coffee and want a cleaner version of that effect. **Who this is NOT for:** Anyone caffeine-sensitive, anyone with hypertension, anyone pregnant, anyone using stimulant medication without clearing it with a clinician.

WHERE TO BUY

[L-Theanine 200mg on Amazon](#) · [Caffeine + L-Theanine combo on Amazon](#)

Memory Builder (Bacopa Monnieri)

Better memory recall and learning over weeks-to-months of consistent use.

Ingredients & doses (per day):

- Bacopa monnieri extract standardized to $\geq 50\%$ bacosides: 300 mg
- Take with a meal containing fat — bacosides are fat-soluble.
- Effects build over 8–12 weeks of daily use. This is not an acute nootropic.

EVIDENCE SUMMARY

- Stough et al. (2001) — 300 mg/day of standardized Bacopa for 12 weeks improved speed of visual information processing, learning rate, and memory consolidation in healthy adults ([PubMed: 11498727](#)).
- Calabrese et al. (2008) — 300 mg/day for 12 weeks enhanced AVLT delayed word recall and reduced depression and anxiety scores in 48 community-dwelling adults aged 65+ ([PubMed: 18611150](#)).
- Morgan & Stevens (2010) — 300 mg/day BacoMind for 12 weeks improved verbal learning and delayed recall on the Rey AVLT in 81 healthy adults over 55 ([PubMed: 20590480](#)).

HONEST FRAMING

Bacopa improved verbal memory recall on the order of a 9–12% delta over placebo across these trials. That is a real, replicated effect — and it is not a "limitless pill." It is a quiet, slow-building improvement on memory tasks in adults who took it daily for 3 months.

HEDGE

GI side effects (loose stools, mild nausea) are common at the start. Take with food and consider splitting the dose AM/PM for the first two weeks.

Who this is for: Students, researchers, anyone preparing for a sustained learning project who can commit to 8–12 weeks. **Who this is NOT for:** Anyone wanting an acute "today" effect. Anyone on thyroid medication (animal data suggests a possible interaction — clear with your clinician).

WHERE TO BUY

[Bacopa monnieri 50% bacosides on Amazon](#)

Lion's Mane (*Hericium erinaceus*)

Mild cognitive support, particularly in older adults; possible neurotrophic factor support.

Ingredients & doses (per day):

- Lion's Mane fruiting-body extract (look for verified beta-glucan content, ideally $\geq 25\%$): 1,000 mg, split AM/midday
- Avoid mycelium-on-grain products that don't separate the mushroom from the substrate.

EVIDENCE SUMMARY

- Mori et al. (2009) — 3 g/day of Yamabushitake (*Hericium erinaceus*) for 16 weeks improved cognitive function scores (HDS-R) in 30 Japanese adults aged 50–80 with mild cognitive impairment; the benefit faded 4 weeks after discontinuation ([PubMed: 18844328](#)).
- Saito et al. (2019) — 12-week double-blind RCT in older adults; oral *Hericium erinaceus* significantly improved MMSE scores and prevented deterioration ([PubMed: 31413233](#)).

HONEST FRAMING — TIER 2 WITH A HEDGE:

The Mori 2009 trial is the most-cited piece of evidence here, and it was small ($n = 30$) and in adults with mild cognitive impairment, not healthy young adults. The "Lion's Mane regrows your brain" claim you see on TikTok is overreach — the *mechanism* (NGF stimulation) is supported in cell and animal work, but human evidence in healthy adults is thin. We include it because the evidence we do have is consistent and the safety profile is clean.

Who this is for: Older adults looking for cognitive support; people who want to try a mushroom adaptogen with the most human data of any of them. **Who this is NOT for:** Anyone expecting a same-day acute effect, or anyone with a known mushroom allergy.

WHERE TO BUY

[Lion's Mane fruiting-body extract on Amazon](#)

Stress Resilience (Rhodiola Rosea)

Reduced fatigue and improved mental performance under stress.

Ingredients & doses (per day):

- Rhodiola rosea extract standardized to 3% rosavins / 1% salidroside (SHR-5 or equivalent): 200–400 mg, taken AM on an empty stomach
- Effects can be acute (same-day) for fatigue; full effect over 4 weeks.

EVIDENCE SUMMARY

- Olsson et al. (2009) — 576 mg/day SHR-5 extract for 28 days reduced burnout-related fatigue and improved attention in 60 adults aged 20–55 with stress-related fatigue ([PubMed: 19016404](#)).
- Darbinyan et al. (2007) — 6-week double-blind RCT in 89 adults with mild-to-moderate depression; SHR-5 at 340 or 680 mg/day reduced overall depression, insomnia, emotional instability and somatization vs. placebo ([PubMed: 17990195](#)).
- Edwards et al. (2012) — Open-label trial in 101 adults with life-stress symptoms; 200 mg twice daily Rhodiola WS® 1375 produced clinically relevant reductions in stress symptoms, disability, and functional impairment over 4 weeks ([PubMed: 22228617](#)).

HONEST FRAMING

The strongest evidence is for **fatigue reduction under stress**, not raw cognitive enhancement in unstressed people. Effect sizes are moderate. The Edwards 2012 study is open-label (no placebo arm) — useful as supportive but not headline evidence.

Who this is for: People in a high-demand work or study sprint, or recovering from burnout-adjacent fatigue.

Who this is NOT for: Anyone on antidepressants (potential serotonergic interaction — clear with your clinician). Anyone with bipolar disorder (case reports of activation).

WHERE TO BUY

[Rhodiola rosea 3% rosavins on Amazon](#)

Cognitive Endurance (Creatine Monohydrate)

Improved cognitive performance under sleep deprivation, mental fatigue, or low energy availability.

Ingredients & doses (per day):

- Creatine monohydrate: 5 g/day, every day, with or without food
- No loading phase needed for cognitive purposes.

EVIDENCE SUMMARY

- Rae et al. (2003) — 5 g/day creatine for 6 weeks improved working memory (backward digit span) and intelligence (Raven's Advanced Progressive Matrices) in 45 healthy young vegetarian adults ([PubMed: 14561278](#)).
- McMorris et al. (2007) — 7-day creatine pre-loading (5 g, four times daily) attenuated central-executive task decrements at 36 hours of sleep deprivation with intermittent moderate exercise ([PubMed: 17046034](#)).
- Avgerinos et al. (2018) — Systematic review of 6 RCTs (n = 281) concluded short-term memory and intelligence/reasoning may be improved by creatine in healthy individuals; the authors flagged stressed and aging populations as warranting future investigation ([PubMed: 29704637](#)).

HONEST FRAMING

Creatine's cognitive benefits are most pronounced under metabolic stress (sleep deprivation, vegetarian/vegan diet, demanding cognitive load). In well-rested, omnivorous, low-stress conditions the effect is smaller and harder to feel. This is one of the safest and best-studied supplements ever made — but its cognitive headline effect is "more resilient when conditions are bad," not "smarter when conditions are good."

Who this is for: Students pulling long stretches, anyone on a vegetarian/vegan diet (who tends to have lower baseline creatine), anyone who trains hard. **Who this is NOT for:** People with kidney disease (talk to a clinician). Note: creatine causes ~1–2 lb of water-weight gain — that is not fat.

WHERE TO BUY

[Creatine monohydrate \(micronized\) on Amazon](#)

Mood + Cognition Foundation (Omega-3 EPA/DHA)

Cognitive support, mood support, and a structural foundation for the brain over months and years.

Ingredients & doses (per day):

- EPA + DHA combined: 1,000–2,000 mg/day from fish oil or algal oil
- Look for third-party tested products (IFOS, USP) and a low oxidation marker (TOTOX < 10).

EVIDENCE SUMMARY

- Yurko-Mauro et al. (2010) MIDAS trial — 900 mg/day DHA for 24 weeks improved Paired Associates Learning errors and Verbal Recognition Memory in 485 adults aged 55+ with age-related cognitive decline ([PubMed: 20434961](#)).
- Stonehouse et al. (2013) — 1.16 g/day DHA for 6 months improved reaction times of episodic and working memory in 176 healthy adults aged 18–45; episodic-memory accuracy improvement was significant in women only ([PubMed: 23515006](#)).
- Witte et al. (2014) — 26-week RCT; 2.2 g/day long-chain omega-3 improved executive function and white-matter microstructural integrity in 65 healthy adults aged 50–75 ([PubMed: 23796946](#)).

HONEST FRAMING

Omega-3s are foundational, not flashy. The cognitive deltas are small per study, but they replicate across populations and outcomes, and they compound over time. If your diet has < 2 servings of fatty fish per week, this is the highest-leverage supplement in this PDF.

Who this is for: Almost everyone — but especially anyone with a low fish intake, vegetarian/vegan readers (consider algal oil for DHA), and people over 50. **Who this is NOT for:** Anyone on blood thinners (clear high doses with your clinician). Anyone with a fish or shellfish allergy — use algal oil instead.

WHERE TO BUY

[Triple-strength fish oil \(EPA + DHA\) on Amazon](#) · [Algal oil DHA on Amazon](#)

Calm Mind (Ashwagandha)

Reduced perceived stress and lower cortisol over 4–8 weeks.

Ingredients & doses (per day):

- Ashwagandha root extract (KSM-66, Sensoril, or Shoden): 240–600 mg/day
- Take with food. Effects build over 4 weeks.

EVIDENCE SUMMARY

- Chandrasekhar et al. (2012) — 300 mg of high-concentration Ashwagandha root extract (KSM-66) twice daily for 60 days produced significant reductions across all stress-assessment scales ($P < 0.0001$) and serum cortisol ($P = 0.0006$) vs. placebo in 64 chronically stressed adults; the published paper reports deltas on the order of ~44% PSS and ~28% cortisol ([PubMed: 23439798](#)).
- Salve et al. (2019) — 250 mg/day or 600 mg/day Withania somnifera root extract for 8 weeks reduced PSS scores and serum cortisol vs. placebo in 60 healthy adults ([PubMed: 32021735](#)).
- Lopresti et al. (2019) — 240 mg/day standardized Ashwagandha extract (Shoden) for 60 days reduced HAM-A anxiety scores and morning cortisol vs. placebo in 60 healthy adults with self-reported high stress ([PubMed: 31517876](#)).

HONEST FRAMING

The cortisol reduction is real and replicated, across multiple branded extracts (KSM-66, Shoden, and a generic root extract). The "lower stress score" is a self-report measure — useful, but not the same as a behavioral or physiological outcome. Effect sizes for stress reduction in these trials were moderate-to-large, but the populations were specifically chronically stressed adults — a healthier, lower-stress baseline will likely show smaller benefits.

Who this is for: Adults with sustained life stress; people who want to support sleep onset (it's mildly sedating for some). **Who this is NOT for:** Pregnant or breastfeeding people. Anyone with hyperthyroidism (ashwagandha can raise thyroid hormones — case reports). Anyone on thyroid medication (clear with your clinician). Anyone with autoimmune conditions on immunosuppressants.

WHERE TO BUY

[Ashwagandha KSM-66 600mg on Amazon](#)

Cognitive Performance Under Pressure (L-Tyrosine)

Maintained cognitive performance during acute stress, sleep loss, or cold exposure.

Ingredients & doses (per dose):

- L-Tyrosine: 100–150 mg per kg of bodyweight, taken 30–60 minutes before a stressor
- For most adults, that's 7–12 g — but practical clinical doses in trials have been 2 g with measurable effects.
- Do NOT take with high-protein meals (competing amino acids reduce absorption).

EVIDENCE SUMMARY

- Mahoney et al. (2007) — 150 mg/kg L-tyrosine (in two food bars before each of two 90-minute cold-water immersions) increased correct responses on a Match-to-Sample working-memory task vs. placebo ([PubMed: 17585971](#)).
- Steenbergen, Sellaro, Hommel & Colzato (2015) — L-tyrosine reduced task-switching costs (improved cognitive flexibility) vs. placebo in 22 healthy adults in a double-blind, randomized, controlled design ([PubMed: 25598314](#)).
- Neri et al. (1995) — 150 mg/kg L-tyrosine, in split doses, attenuated the usual decline on a psychomotor task and reduced lapse probability on a high-event-rate vigilance task during ~13 hours of extended wakefulness ([PubMed: 7794222](#)).

HONEST FRAMING

L-Tyrosine helps the brain replenish dopamine and norepinephrine when those neurotransmitters are being depleted by acute stress. Translation: it does *not* make a well-rested, calm person sharper — it helps a stressed person stay closer to baseline. It is a situational tool, not a daily one.

Who this is for: Pre-exam, pre-presentation, post-poor-sleep, jet-lagged, cold-exposed (literally). **Who this is NOT for:** Anyone on MAO inhibitors. Anyone with hyperthyroidism. Anyone with melanoma history (tyrosine is a melanin precursor — talk to a clinician). It is not effective if you take it daily; the body adapts.

WHERE TO BUY

[L-Tyrosine 500mg on Amazon](#)

Choline-Boosted Focus (Citicoline / CDP-Choline)

Improved attention, processing speed, and memory consolidation.

Ingredients & doses (per day):

- Citicoline (CDP-Choline) — Cognizin is the most-studied form: 250–500 mg/day
- Take with breakfast.

EVIDENCE SUMMARY

- McGlade et al. (2019) — 250 or 500 mg/day citicoline for 28 days improved attention and psychomotor speed and decreased impulsivity vs. placebo in 75 healthy adolescent males ([PubMed: 26179181](#)).
- Alvarez-Sabín et al. (2013) — 1 g/day citicoline for 12 months in 347 first-ever ischemic stroke patients improved attention-executive function and temporal orientation vs. control ([PubMed: 23406981](#)).

HONEST FRAMING

Citicoline is a precursor to phosphatidylcholine (a brain cell membrane component) and a source of choline for acetylcholine production. The healthy-population evidence is thinner than the marketing suggests — the cleanest signal we have is in adolescent males (McGlade 2019); large adult-only RCTs are limited. The strongest evidence is in clinical populations (post-stroke vascular cognitive impairment) — relevant for older readers, less directly translatable to healthy 25-year-olds.

Who this is for: Older adults, anyone on a low-egg / low-meat diet (they tend to be low on choline), anyone running a stack with a cholinergic component (e.g., racetams — beyond this PDF's scope). **Who this is NOT for:** Anyone with bipolar disorder (case reports of activation). Anyone who has taken citicoline and felt agitated — it is cholinergic, and not everyone tolerates it.

WHERE TO BUY

[Cognizin Citicoline 250mg on Amazon](#)

Memory Maintenance (Phosphatidylserine)

Memory and learning support, particularly in older adults.

Ingredients & doses (per day):

- Phosphatidylserine (soy- or sunflower-derived): 100 mg, three times daily (300 mg/day total)
- Take with meals containing fat.

EVIDENCE SUMMARY

- Vakhapova et al. (2010) — Phosphatidylserine + omega-3 (PS-DHA) for 15 weeks significantly improved verbal immediate recall in 157 non-demented older adults with memory complaints; gains in immediate and delayed recall, learning, and processing speed were strongest in those with higher baseline cognition ([PubMed: 20523044](#)).
- Kato-Kataoka et al. (2010) — 100 mg or 300 mg/day soybean-derived phosphatidylserine for 6 months improved memory functions in elderly Japanese subjects with memory complaints; gains in delayed verbal recall were strongest in those with lower baseline scores ([PubMed: 21103034](#)).
- Crook et al. (1991) — 100 mg phosphatidylserine three times daily (300 mg/day) for 12 weeks in 149 adults with age-associated memory impairment improved learning and memory tasks of daily life vs. placebo ([PubMed: 2027477](#)).

HONEST FRAMING — TIER 2 WITH HEDGES:

The memory-improvement evidence is strongest in older adults with subjective memory complaints, not healthy young adults. Some older PS trials (Crook 1991) used bovine-derived PS, which is no longer commercially available (BSE / mad-cow concerns); modern products use soy or sunflower lecithin, and we don't have a head-to-head efficacy comparison. PS is also widely marketed for cortisol reduction during exercise — that evidence is weaker and we are not making that claim here.

Who this is for: Adults 50+ who want a memory-focused stack with reasonable human evidence, often paired with omega-3s. **Who this is NOT for:** Anyone with a soy allergy (use sunflower-derived). Anyone expecting a same-day effect.

WHERE TO BUY

[Phosphatidylserine 100mg on Amazon](#)

How to actually use this PDF

1. **Pick one stack at a time.** Do not start three at once — you won't know what is working.
2. **Give it the time the studies gave it.** Bacopa needs 8–12 weeks. Ashwagandha needs 4–8. Caffeine + L-theanine works the same day. Match your expectations to the timeline.
3. **Track one outcome.** Memory recall, sleep onset, perceived stress at 5 PM — pick one thing and rate it daily on a 1–10 scale. Real signal beats vibes.
4. **If a stack isn't working at the duration the study used, stop.** A nootropic that doesn't work for *you* isn't a moral failing. Stop and try the next one.

What we deliberately left off this list

We left off: **modafinil and racetams** (prescription / grey-market, beyond an introductory list); **nicotine** (effective at low doses, but the addictive-substance disclosure and harm-reduction conversation deserves its own piece); **psilocybin microdosing** (the human RCT evidence on cognitive endpoints is weaker than the hype suggests); **noopept and phenylpiracetam** (regulatory grey area in the US, evidence base is thinner than the marketing).

If we cited it loudly, we believed it. If we left it off, we didn't.

Sources & disclosure

- Every claim in this PDF is linked to a PubMed citation. If you find a dead link or a citation that doesn't support the claim, write to us at info@nootropicstacker.com and we will fix it in the next revision.
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info@nootropicstacker.com